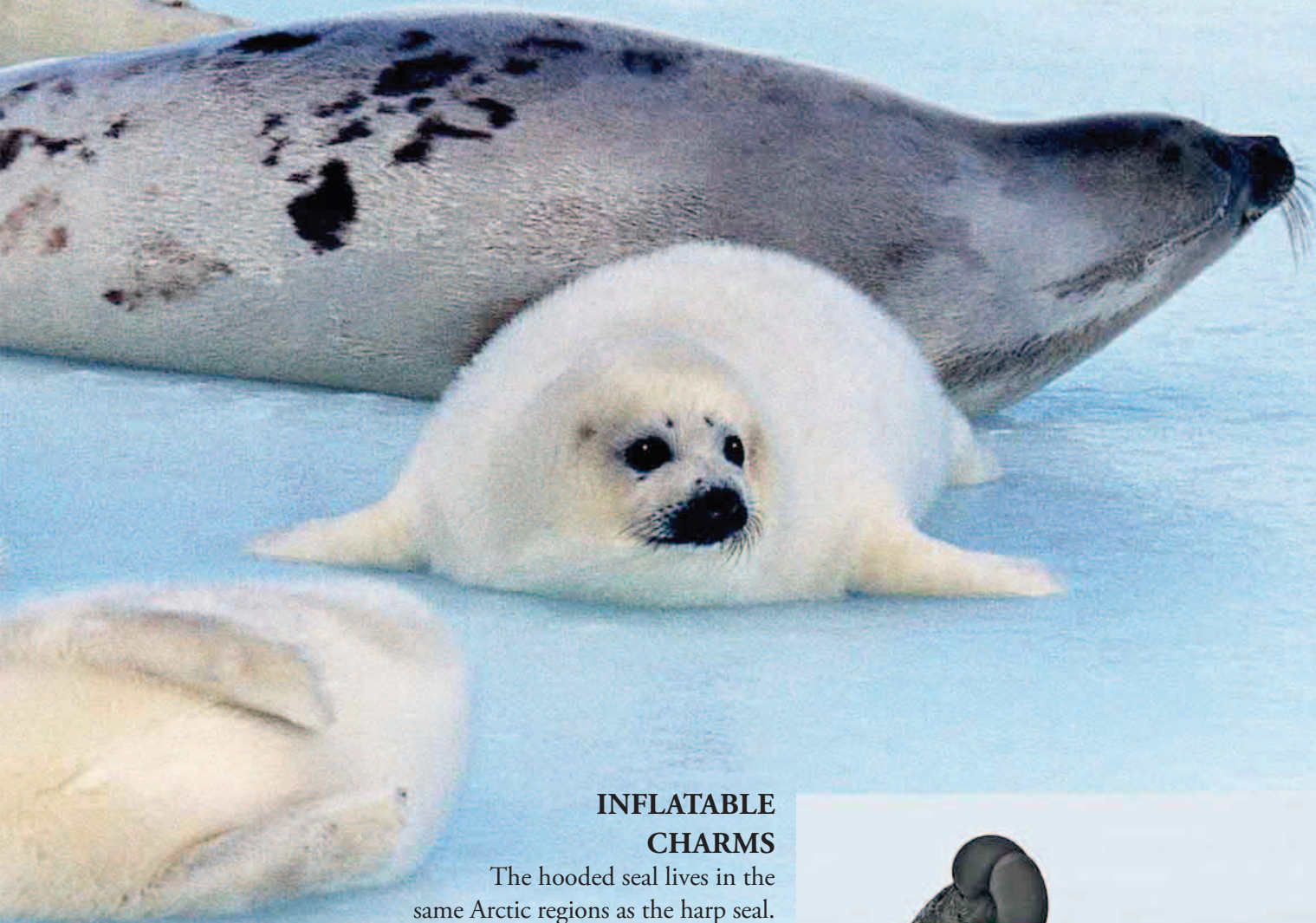


WHITE COATS

The pups of Antarctic seals are gray, like their parents. But in the Arctic, dark-coated seal pups would be easy targets on the ice for predatory polar bears. This may explain why most Arctic ice-breeding seals are born with white coats, which camouflage them against the ice and snow. The very thick white fur also helps keep out the cold, but it soon falls away to reveal a darker, sleeker coat.

► MOLTING PUP

Although it is only about eight weeks old, this ringed seal pup is already losing the coat of long white fur that it was born with. It will soon look very different.



INFLATABLE CHARMS

The hooded seal lives in the same Arctic regions as the harp seal. During the spring breeding season, the adult males compete with each other by performing a spectacular display. Each male seal fills the top of his black snout with air to create the swollen “hood” that gives the seal its name. He can also inflate a balloon of red skin that emerges from his left nostril, and shake this from side to side to make a loud ping-pong sound. The males use this display to try and drive off their rivals, but often end up fighting instead.

